

Rubens

The greatest Baroque painter and leading exponent of Catholic art in northern Europe, Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640) created fluid, luminous works of great energy, inspired by Michelangelo, Tintoretto and Caravaggio, and infused with his own sensual vitality. His talents and interests made him one of the most versatile and prolific artists of the era, perfectly suited to the ostentatious tastes of the age, and the great demand for his work meant he had an exceptionally large and busy studio. During the Counter-Reformation, his innovations helped to define Antwerp as one of Europe's major artistic cities. Working in Italy from 1600 to 1608, Rubens studied classical antiquity, Renaissance art and contemporary work by painters such as Caravaggio. Whether in landscapes, portraits, allegories or religious stories, his work was vigorous, decorative and theatrical. He preferred smooth wood panels to canvas, and his inventive compositions featured colour contrasts, harmonies, textures and expressions of passion and joy. His female figures became known for their abundance of rosy flesh.



Rubens, *The Three Graces*, c.1635